An Argument for Gradient Grammaticality

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IDEA

Reasoning

Premises:

- **Syntactic selectional restrictions are part of the grammar.** (assumption)
- **Syntactic selectional restrictions are gradient.** (observation; see experiments)

Conclusion:

- **Grammaticality is gradient.**

Selectional restrictions

Semantic selectional restrictions:

- for example, *depend* is acceptable with a proposition, but *wait* is not:
  - ▷ *You may depend on the fact that he will be on time.*
  - ▷ **You may wait for the fact that he will be on time.*

Syntactic selectional restrictions:

- for example, *depend* is acceptable with a PP[*on*], but not with an NP:
  - ▷ *You may depend* [$_{\text{PP}}$ *on my assistant*].
  - ▷ **You may depend* [$_{\text{NP}}$ *my assistant*].
- not clear to what extent acceptable with a CP[*that*], e.g.:
  - ▷ ?*You may depend* [$_{\text{CP}}$ *that he will be on time*].

EXPERIMENTS

Method

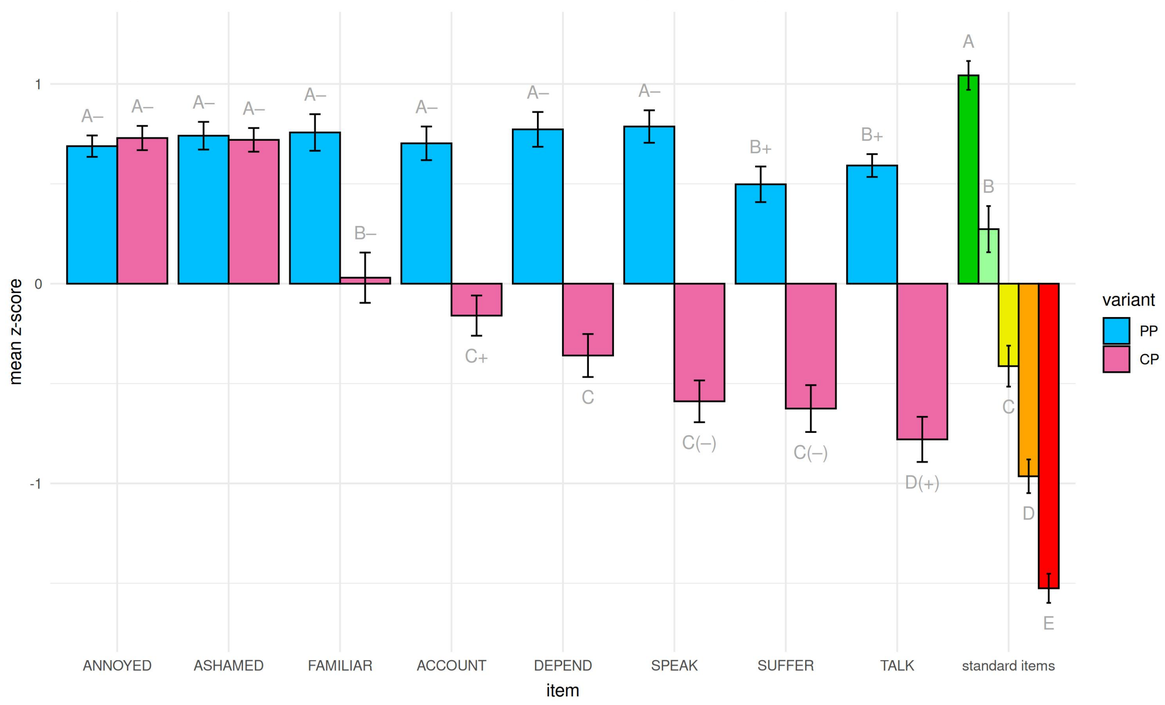
- **acceptability judgement experiments**;
- various predicates (*depend*, *familiar*...);
- 8–9 items per predicate;
- Thermometer Method;
- standard items among fillers (roughly: A, B – grammatical, C – borderline, D, E – ungrammatical);
- **linear mixed-effects modelling**.

Experiment 1

(1) Justin Bieber can **depend**...

a. ...[$_{\text{PP}}$ **on** the fact [$_{\text{CP}}$ that his fans still love his early songs]].

b. ...[$_{\text{CP}}$ **that** his fans still love his early songs].



Results:

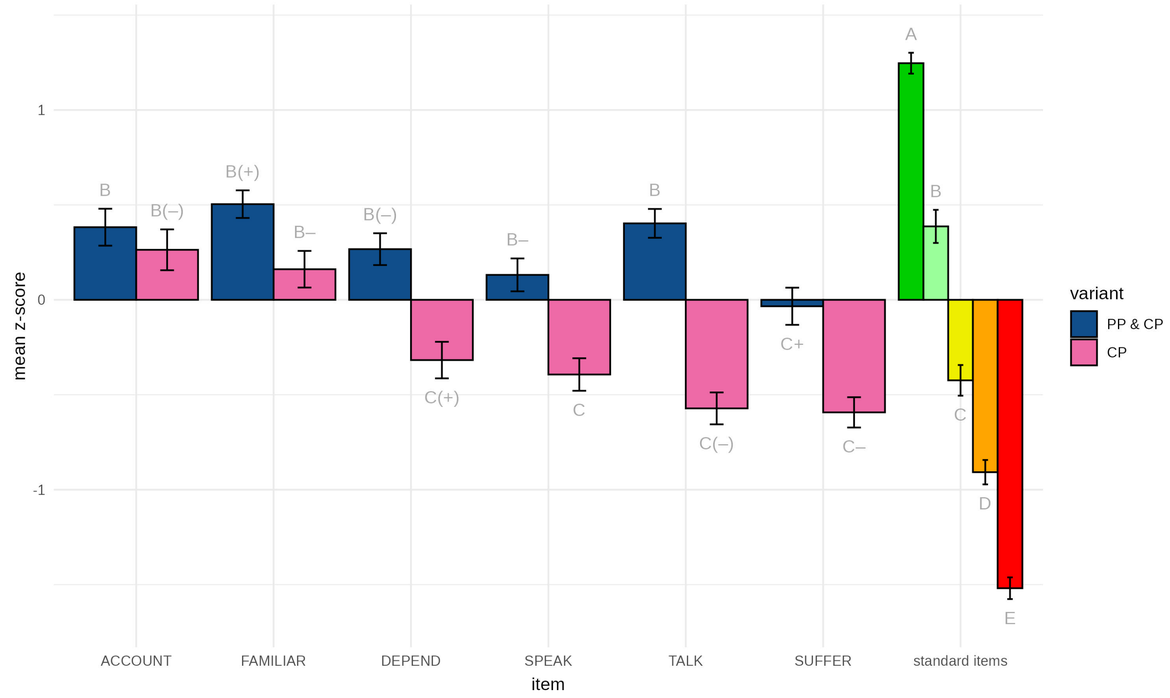
- **all** these predicates are **semantically acceptable with propositions**;
- but they **vary** in the extent to which they are **syntactically acceptable with CP[*that*]s**.

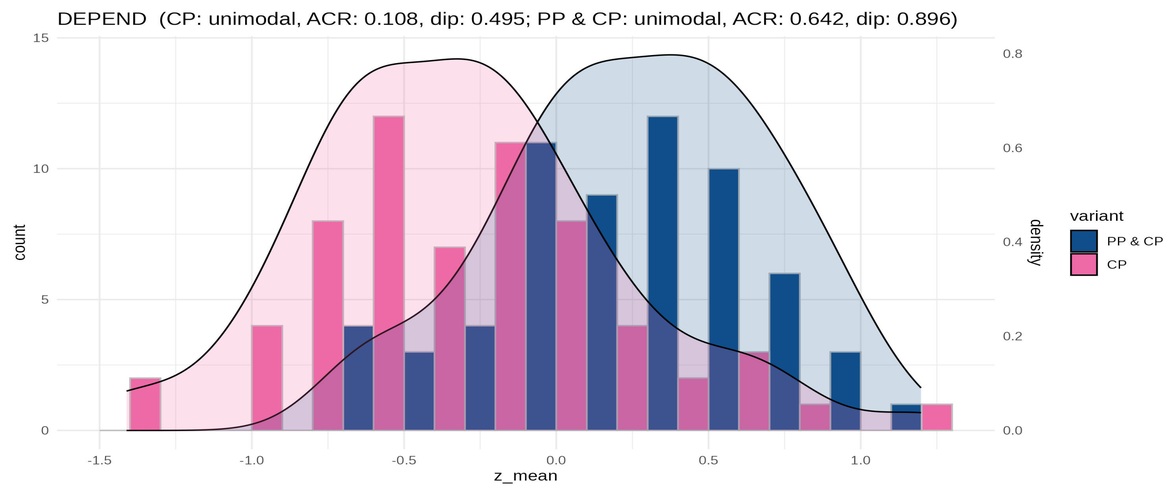
Experiment 2

(2) My children can **depend**...

a. ...[[$_{\text{PP}}$ **on** me] **and** [$_{\text{CP}}$ **that** I will always be there for them]].

b. ...[$_{\text{CP}}$ **that** I will always be there for them].





Results:

- **gradience of combinations with CP[*that*]s** confirmed;
- **distance effects in coordination** (see the "When Verbs Forget" poster on Saturday);
- **no bimodality** – genuine gradience of selectional restriction!

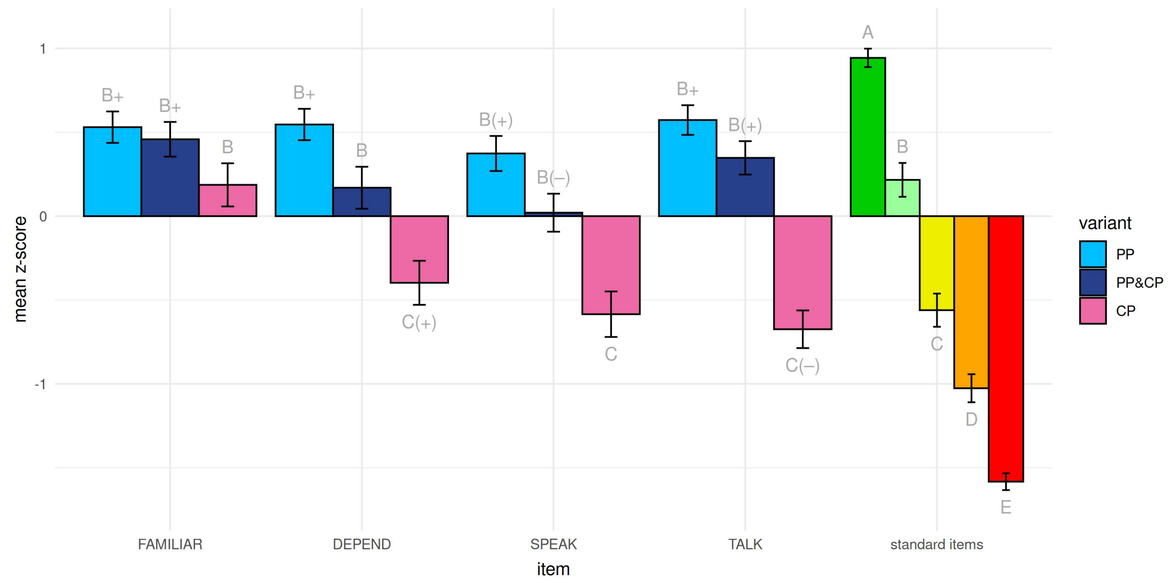
Experiment 3

(3) Justin Bieber can **depend**...

a. ...[$_{\text{PP}}$ **on** [[$_{\text{NP}}$ his fans]$_i$ and [$_{\text{NP}}$ the fact [$_{\text{CP}}$ that they$_i$ still love his early songs]]]].

b. ...[[$_{\text{PP}}$ **on** [$_{\text{NP}}$ his fans]$_i$] **and** [$_{\text{CP}}$ **that** they$_i$ still love his early songs]].

c. ...[$_{\text{CP}}$ **that** [$_{\text{NP}}$ his fans]$_i$ still love his early songs].



Results confirm:

- **gradience of syntactic selections for CP[*that*]**
  - ▷ (despite high semantic acceptance of PPs denoting propositions);
- **distance effects in coordination**.

FULL PAPER

Under review, but **available on demand** – talk to us or write to us.

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